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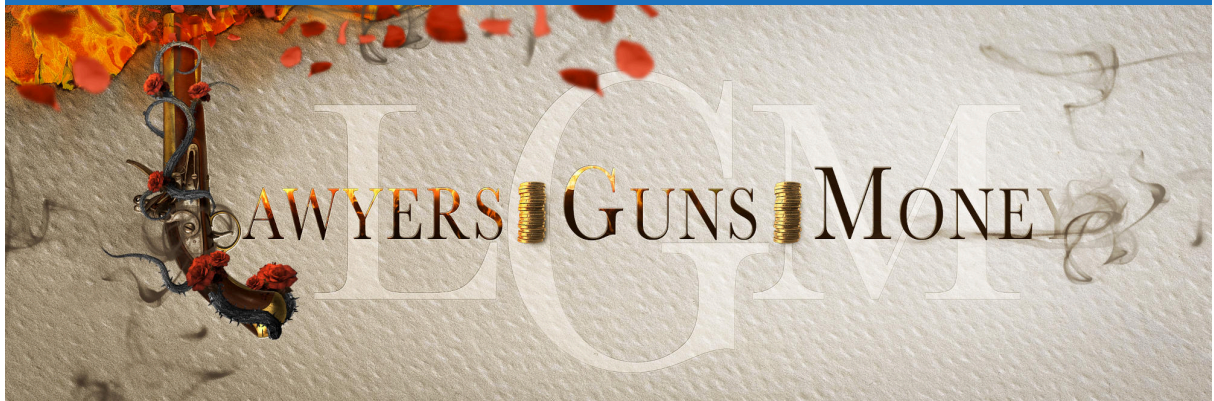
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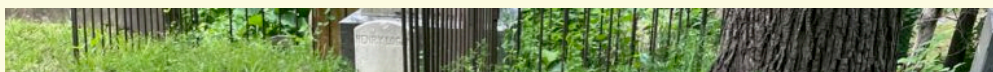
Erik Visits an American Grave, Part 1,380

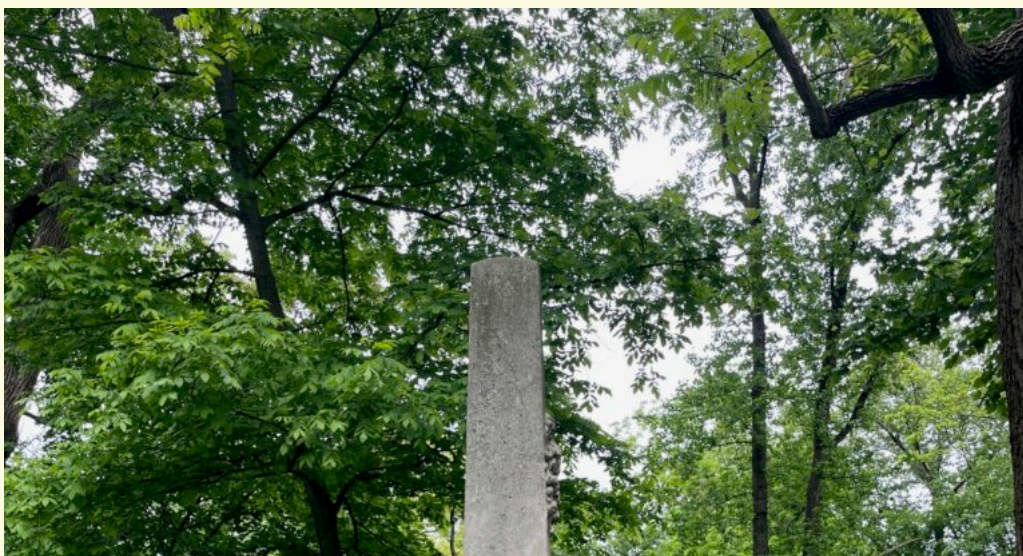


BY [ERIK LOOMIS](#) / ON JUNE 22, 2023 / AT 7:00 AM / IN [GENERAL](#)

1738 VIEWS

These are some of the graves at Mount Zion Cemetery and Female Union Band Cemetery, historically Black cemeteries in Washington, D.C. This was a special request by someone who funded the trip and, as always, I am very happy to go see whoever you want if you are willing to put up the expenses for it.







I don't have any good way to tell any meaningful stories about any of the individuals here. What you can see is that a few of the stones are still standing but most aren't. The people taking care of these cemeteries, which really is one cemetery with different names for each side, have piled most of the stones in the middle, probably to protect them from people walking on them, though that's an assumption. These cemeteries were for the Black community in Georgetown, long one of Washington's wealthiest districts. More on the people taking care of these cemeteries in a minute, but a visit here is a great way to get into how segregation and discrimination continues beyond the grave. This is right next to Oak Hill Cemetery, one of the city's most august cemeteries, holding the city's elite, including [Ben Bradlee](#), who we have covered recently. It's hard for me to imagine a more visual way to tell about Georgetown's inequality than to compare Bradlee's monstrosity to these graves. This is a common story we have seen throughout this series, including when I was in Richmond visiting the graves of people ranging from [Maggie Walker](#) to [Arthur Ashe](#) and was horrified at the state of the cemeteries. This stuff takes money, time, and volunteers. You know what poor people don't have? Money, time, and the ability to volunteer. You know what rich white people have? Money, time, and the ability to volunteer.

Well, the Mount Zion-Female Union Band Society does a heck of a good job of working with this site for a bunch of people without a lot of resources. There's a URL you can scan in the cemetery to get some information while you are there. [They have a good website explaining a lot of this.](#) There's a lot of detail in here. The cemeteries go back to 1808, when Ebenezer Eliason paid \$500 for it to bury both whites and their slaves. This was part of a Methodist church that actually accepted both races as members, even though it was segregated inside the church. Still, this was quite unusual. I'm not really sure how many whites were ever buried there, but there were burials of Black Georgetown residents pretty early. Oak Hill opened in 1849 and there's no question that after that there were basically no white burials at Mount Zion. In addition, most of the whites already buried there were moved to the new cemetery.

The Female Union Band Society was a group of both free Black and Native women in the area. It was a sort of fraternal organization that provided what most of these existed for at the time—burial insurance. It bought the land next to this cemetery in 1842 and guaranteed you a respectable burial if you paid into it. These cemeteries were already falling apart by the late nineteenth century. Who had the money to take care of it in the Gilded Age Black community in DC? It was however a popular place on Decoration Day. The federal government bought a piece of the cemeteries in 1931 to build the Rock Creek Parkway. The last burial was in 1950 and the DC government barred future burials in 1953, concerned about sanitation, which is the point of burial in the first place. The Mount Zion Church bought the Female Union Band side in 1960. There was a bunch of complicated legal stuff around this though. There were claimants to the Female Union people that showed up later. There was good chance all these people were going to be disinterred and moved somewhere else so the land could be developed for rich people's housing. But the local Black community rallied and in 1964, began the process of preserving the site and fighting the disinternments. They won this battle in 1975 and the cemetery was preserved. Since then, local volunteers have slowly built up their ability to take care of it, though the current group did not start until 2006 and there have been continued legal battles over ownership of the property. They definitely need more volunteers, so if you are in DC and interested in these things, contact them!

The burial vault is interesting because there is a strong chance that it was used as a hiding place on the Underground Railroad. The National Park Service is presently investigating this and if true, it would be able to provide greater resources to the whole project.

The last thing I will say here is that I am very open to suggestions if you want to be a patron of this series. An individual contacted me, we talked about expenses, and agreed that \$300 would be an appropriate amount for me to visit DC and do this. And as requested, I have. [The donations for this series 100% go to the travel expenses.](#) Of course in truth it did cost more than \$300 to go to DC, but between that and the smaller donations that aren't dedicated to anything in particular, I was able to do it, plus go to Rock Creek again and a couple of other places, such as that [Hugh Jones grave on Maryland's eastern shore I covered a few days back](#). So...let me know if you'd like me to do something for you here! Am happy to talk about it at the very least! Previous posts in this series are archived [here](#) and [here](#).

[.....Meanwhile, this story came out last night:](#)

They are all gone. The laminated birthday cards. The plastic toy piano. The doll with the blue bow on her head.

Strangers have carried toys into one of the oldest Black cemeteries in the nation's capital and placed them near the grave marker of a girl who lived long ago and not long enough. They brought them for Nannie, and for years, to the amazement of people who regularly visit the cemetery, many of those gifts remained undisturbed.

The weather didn't destroy them. Animals didn't carry them off. Visitors didn't steal them.

Then came Tuesday. On that day, as Lisa Fager tells it, when she went to show a group of George Washington University students Nannie's marker, she found that someone had set the site on fire. Instead of toys and cards, she saw melted plastic and blackened stone.

The moment she realized what happened, she screamed. Then, she cried. Hours later, she was still trying to process what she saw.

"It's a child's grave," she told me. "Who would do that?"

Fager is the executive director of the [Black Georgetown Foundation](#), which has been working to restore two adjoining historic Black cemeteries — the Mount Zion and Female Union Band Society cemeteries — and fill in details about the lives of the people who are buried there.

Fager first told me about Nannie two years ago, and I shared with you how her grave marker had pulled at strangers and left them with questions: Who was she? Had she lived free or enslaved? Who was leaving the laminated cards and vintage toys that appeared at the site around her birthday?

Even during the most uncertain stretch of the pandemic, when people were isolating, someone made the effort to leave a card that read "Happy Birthday, Nannie!"

"There is a power to Nannie's story, even with the unknowns, or maybe even more so because of them," I wrote at the time. "She is drawing people to a historic Black cemetery and making them consider what life in Georgetown might have looked like for a Black girl in the 1850s. She is making strangers think about human connections — then and now."

So, uh, yeah, discrimination absolutely continues past death in this sick country.

[black cemeteries, graves](#)

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Profiles in something

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Erik Visits an American Grave, Part 1,846

3 days ago · 125 comments

This is the grave of P.G.T. Beauregard. Born in 1818 in St. Bernard Parish, ...

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• Share

Best Newest Oldest



Just Sayin ⁺ 🗳️ ⭐ 📢 +3

2 years ago

Oh yeah, all right
Are you going to be in my dreams
Tonight?
And in the end
The ~~love~~-hate you take
Is equal to the ~~love~~ hate you make

👍 2 💬 0 Reply Share ›



Dr. Ronnie James, D.O. ⁺ 🗳️ ⭐ 📢 +3

2 years ago edited

Black Americans have been the heroes of our national story this entire time. That American Blacks have experienced the

Black Americans have been the heroes of our national story this entire time. That American Blacks have experienced the country as a place of kidnaping, enslavement, slavery, indentured servitude, infanticide, family separation, race based murder rape and mayhem, and still manage to contribute so many of the greatest things in our history is one of the most astonishing things humanity has ever accomplished. America will exist as a country that allows Black people to fully enjoy all the rights privileges and fruits of its labor, or it will not exist at all.

👍 24 🗨️ 0 Reply Share >



DavidtheK 🧑🏻 + 🌟 🍷 🍷 🍷 🍷 ➔ Dr. Ronnie James, D.O.

2 years ago

I'm saving this for whenever I see a social media post about the "problems" in African-American society. I hope also to be able to memorize it and deliver it in person whenever someone tells me African-Americans need to get their act together. Thank you.

👍 3 🗨️ 0 Reply Share >



buckguy 🌟 🍷 🍷 🍷 +2

2 years ago edited

Restoring a cemetery takes a long time and relies on a core group of people. Congressional Cemetery, which is just beyond the Capitol Hill area, was saved by dog walkers who lived nearby and that took decades, in part because of legal issues. That, and it became a popular gay burial site because of the presence of Leonard Matloviitch. DC's historic cemeteries easily disappoint—Oak Hill has some fancy people interred there, but it's basically a warren of graves and Bradlee's grave has had legal problems because it really shouldn't be there and there are long term environmental issues. Rock Creek also has celebs but but otherwise it's a plain, architecturally boring place.

Georgetown was a mostly working class place in its long industrial heyday as DC's port and it didn't lose its industry entirely until the 1970s. It was essentially a separate town within the District for many years and not contiguous with "the Federal City". There were big houses up the hill which began to be gentrified in the 30s, but the areas closer to the Potomac were a mix of African-American, Irish, and German workers' neighborhoods. There also was a small Jewish community and the synagogue is still there along with at least one of the old Black churches. The historic African American neighborhood is the area near Rose Park on the East end. Some accounts claim that Georgetown was mostly African-American but that was never the case. Foggy Bottom, the next neighborhood to the East had a similar ethnic mix, but was mostly leveled for new federal buildings in the 30s and 40s.

My experience is that southern cemeteries are surprisingly poorly kept, even if they have historic. I used to live near Oakland Cemetery in Atlanta, home to the old elite, and it was extremely neglected, although I understand it now has a band of volunteers that is slowly improving things. I also recall the historic "park cemetery" in Nashville also being a poorly maintained disappointment.

👍 14 🗨️ 0 Reply Share >



ganews 🧑🏻 + 🍷 🍷 🍷 +3 ➔ buckguy

2 years ago

I have come to lean that anything and everything done by volunteers without a full-time and decently-paid staff takes a long time and relies on a core group of people, even if funds aren't scarce.

👍 6 🗨️ 0 Reply Share >



allyngibson 🧑🏻 + 🍷 🍷 🍷 ➔ buckguy

2 years ago edited

My great-grandfather's father, several of his siblings, and his aunt (who was insane and killed my great-grandfather's mother) are buried at Congressional Cemetery, and I've visited it a number of times, though not since the pandemic. It's a lovely place now, but I've seen photos of what it looked like in the 60s and 70s, when the church that owns the cemetery (Christ Church, on G Street), didn't have the money for the upkeep. J. Edgar Hoover's burial was a bit of a problem, because the cemetery was in such poor shape and it took some nearby residents coming in with push mowers to clear enough of it to make it presentable to a national audience.

My great-grandfather's mother is in Baltimore's Loudon Park, which is pretty and decently well maintained (though there's a dead tree problem), but the area where she's buried (which is downhill of Babe Ruth's father) had a tendency to flood. I've seen the area when it's been a massive lake—pretty, but very sad.

One of the saddest cemeteries I've visited is Baltimore's Mt. Carmel, off 95 on O'Donnell Street. I worked near there for a few months, I'd see it from the highway when I went home, and I'd think, "I should visit there. I might have family there." I do not know if I do, though my great-grandfather's brother-in-law is there, and I thought there was a chance my great-great-grandfather Thomas Feenhagen might be there. Mt. Carmel was reputed to be one of the most beautiful cemeteries in the country when it opened. Today, it's a place of sadness and neglect. It was allowed to grow fallow, there are sections of the cemetery that are inaccessible because trees and briars grew unchecked, and it was (when I was there) clearly the site of youthful drinking. You can stand at the edge of a cleared area and see headstones among the briars out of reach. It was fascinating to see so many headstones carved in German—the east side of Baltimore was heavily German and

fascinating to see so many headstones carved in German – the east side of Baltimore was heavily German and German-speaking as late as World War I – but I felt a great sorrow at the overall condition of the cemetery.

👍 1 🗨️ 0 Reply Share ›



randy khan 🧑🏻 + 🇺🇸 🇨🇦 🇩🇪 🇬🇧 ➔ buckguy

2 years ago

My wife works for a small historic preservation nonprofit with a name that makes it sound like it's big. She periodically gets calls from local cemetery preservation groups that are desperate for money or help or really anything because the task is beyond them. There are so many cemeteries out there and just neither enough time or money for them.

👍 0 🗨️ 0 Reply Share ›



Malaclypse 🧑🏻 + 🇺🇸 🇨🇦 🇩🇪 🇬🇧 +2

2 years ago

Jesus, I was not ready for that part about Nannie. Devastating.

👍 10 🗨️ 0 Reply Share ›



Derelict 🧑🏻 + 🇺🇸 🇨🇦 🇩🇪 🇬🇧 +3 ➔ Malaclypse

2 years ago

That is some serious fucked-uppedness. Being a somewhat normal person, I simply cannot conceive of any possible motivation to do such a thing.

👍 0 🗨️ 0 Reply Share ›



BigHank53 🧑🏻 + 🇺🇸 🇨🇦 🇩🇪 🇬🇧 +3 ➔ Derelict

2 years ago

I'm guessing (hoping) that it was just your ordinary pair of bored 13-year-olds, for whom setting some shit on fire would still be a colossal transgressive thrill.

A nominal adult doing such a thing is too depressing to bear.

👍 3 🗨️ 0 Reply Share ›



Nobdy 🧑🏻 + 🇺🇸 🇨🇦 🇩🇪 🇬🇧 +3 ➔ BigHank53

2 years ago

There's plenty of shit to set on fire in this world and a 13 year old should know not to burn things that matter to others, though some don't care. As I said in my comment I certainly understood at that age the difference between doing random transgressive stuff and desecrating a memorial. It might have been bored teens but I would hope they weren't "ordinary." I expect more even from teens.

👍 3 🗨️ 0 Reply Share ›



BigHank53 🧑🏻 + 🇺🇸 🇨🇦 🇩🇪 🇬🇧 +3 ➔ Nobdy

2 years ago

Two or three idiots trying to impress each other can get up to much stupider shit than one on their own. But you are correct.

👍 3 🗨️ 0 Reply Share ›



jim 🧑🏻 + 🇺🇸 🇨🇦 🇩🇪 🇬🇧 +2 ➔ BigHank53

2 years ago edited

they always say "safety in numbers" but more often than you'd think it's "danger" or "trouble"

👍 2 🗨️ 0 Reply Share ›



BigHank53 🧑🏻 + 🇺🇸 🇨🇦 🇩🇪 🇬🇧 +3 ➔ jim

2 years ago

The traditional final words of the greater southeastern redneck ("Hold my beer and watch this.") have two embedded prerequisites: both the beer and an idiot to hold it and watch.

👍 1 🗨️ 0 Reply Share ›



Linnaeus 🧑🏻 + 🇺🇸 🇨🇦 🇩🇪 🇬🇧 +3 ➔ BigHank53

2 years ago

I would hope so, too, but given the context, it's hard not to think otherwise.

👍 1 🗨️ 0 Reply Share ›



Nobdy       → Malaclypse

2 years ago

For a long time I was the kind of person who wondered what went through someone's head when they did something like set fire to a makeshift memorial on the grave of a young girl who died a century and a half ago. Like do they think "This is a good thing that I'm doing" or "this is a bad thing but it's fun and will hurt someone." What story do they tell themselves about themselves?

I tell myself stories about myself all the time. When I was about 14 my friend and I hopped the fence into a graveyard after closing and brought in our bikes. We rode around making jokes about the names on the graves. We found a wasp's nest and we threw rocks at it until the wasps chased us off. We told ourselves we weren't hurting anybody and that we attacked the wasps so they wouldn't sting any mourners in the future. We never dreamed off defacing graves or stealing flowers or anything because what positive story can you tell about that? Now that I'm older the story I tell is that we were just bored kids making minor mischief and testing boundaries because that's what teens do. It was stupid but I'm not particularly ashamed of it. Nobody got hurt except some wasps.

So I used to wonder what someone who did something this cruel and pointless would say to justify their actions or if they would try. But the older I get the less it seems to matter. Some people just do horrible things and they may not know why, or their reasons may be so degenerate as to be incomprehensible to the rest of us. People are beautiful and people are cruel and all you can do is try to practice and encourage the former and try to contain as much of the latter as you can. Maybe hope to teach the next generation to cultivate their better instincts, though that's not the lesson they're getting from our country right now.

 6  0 Reply Share ›



Lurker       → Nobdy

2 years ago

You know, I have been raised to honor anthills and wasps' nests as sacrosanct. Bullying small insects and destroying their work is simply abhorrent, and is ample proof of you being an evil person. You were not just doing mischief but taking enjoyment out of the suffering of those weaker than you. "Testing boundaries" is not a defence: this would be forgivable for a three-year old, once. A teenager is liable to know better.

 1  0 Reply Share ›



Sev       → Lurker

2 years ago

This is just too judgmental. Most of us have done and said some shameful and stupid things in our lives. Hopefully we regret and don't repeat. I say this as one who is almost Jainist in my respect for other living things, trap and release wasps rather than killing them. But there are few saints among us.

 2  0 Reply Share ›



Rollo Tomassi       → Nobdy

2 years ago

You know, a few days ago a guy at a concert threw his phone at the singer. (She's famous, but I've never heard of her before, because I'm old.) It hit her in the head and she fell to the ground in pain, ending the concert. She needed several stitches. When he was arrested, he told the police that he did it because he thought it would be funny. What you said about some people having no self-justification, or at least no justification that the rest of us could possibly understand, for doing horrible things certainly seems to apply here. And this was an adult, a man of 27, not a bored teenager pushing boundaries. And as disrespectful as it is to vandalize a grave, it's still not physically assaulting a person for no reason other than your own amusement (with the additional consequence of putting a premature end to an event that literally thousands of people were enjoying.) Anyway, I guess some people just work entirely on impulse, with no regard for others.

 1  0 Reply Share ›



Fraud_Guy       → Nobdy

2 years ago

People are assholes, part the trillionth.

 2  0 Reply Share ›



bookworm1398       → Fraud_Guy

2 years ago

I want to say they were probably stoned and the fire wasn't deliberate but IDK

👍 0 🗨️ 0 Reply Share ›



Tofu Killer

2 years ago edited

There is a very ugly DC history to how non-White cemeteries were regarded and preserved. One recent story was the discovery of headstones from a cemetery that was "in the way" of mass transit development being used as erosion control along the shore of a Virginia Potomac River estate.

<https://www.washingtonpost...>

Also, gravestone tipping has always been a fun way to spend a drunken night, and even outside of any animus, it isn't too hard to do the math about at which racially-defined cemetery you would be more likely to get arrested.

👍 5 🗨️ 0 Reply Share ›



randy khan

2 years ago

I have written about this before, but a few miles from this site there was once a Black cemetery in Alexandria. It was deeded over to the Catholic cemetery across the street at one point, with the explicit stipulation that it would remain a cemetery and not be sold off.

And, I don't think to the surprise of anyone reading this, the Catholic cemetery sold it off, and eventually a gas station and an office building were built on top of it. The stones were removed, but the bodies were not disinterred.

As a result of the Woodrow Wilson Bridge replacement project, Alexandria got funding for various amenities. It bought the property to turn it into a park and a memorial, and part of the project included using ground-penetrating radar to locate the grave sites and mark them.

The whole timeline is here: [Contrabands and Freedman's Cemetery Memorial](#)

👍 9 🗨️ 0 Reply Share ›



Nobdy → randy khan

2 years ago

So the Catholics very kindly didn't even disinter the bodies and yet you STILL reject Adrienne Vermeule's very reasonable ideas about turning the US into a Catholic theocracy?

Who is the real bigot now?

👍 4 🗨️ 0 Reply Share ›



Clark Ashton Kutcher, Unhinged → Nobdy

2 years ago

She obviously is a Ronald Dahl villain come to life.

👍 1 🗨️ 0 Reply Share ›



GeorgeBurnsWasRight → randy khan

2 years ago

In addition to whatever damage to the graves came from the building, digging to install the tanks certainly destroyed a bunch of burials.

👍 1 🗨️ 0 Reply Share ›



randy khan → GeorgeBurnsWasRight

2 years ago

Definitely.

I am not sure whether the City of Alexandria decided to do this on its own (it has a fairly robust Black history program, and long has acknowledged the history of enslavement in the city) or if there was pressure from the community, but either way I am glad they did this. What happened to this cemetery was a travesty.

(As an aside, in looking for a link on the park, I discovered that originally Black Union troops were buried at this site, but that Black soldiers convalescing in Alexandria during the Civil War demanded that the war dead be buried with other troops in Alexandria National Cemetery, which is about a mile away from this site, and - wonder of wonders - the authorities actually did move the Black soldiers to that cemetery.)

👍 1 🗨️ 0 Reply Share ›

I belong to an organization that has both men and women as members, but it's called a "fraternity" nonetheless.

👍 1 💬 0 Reply Share ›



Owlbear1 🧑+ 🌟🌟🌟🌟🌟🌟 ➔ kotodama

2 years ago

Probably, but *massive inferiority complexes* must be coddled.

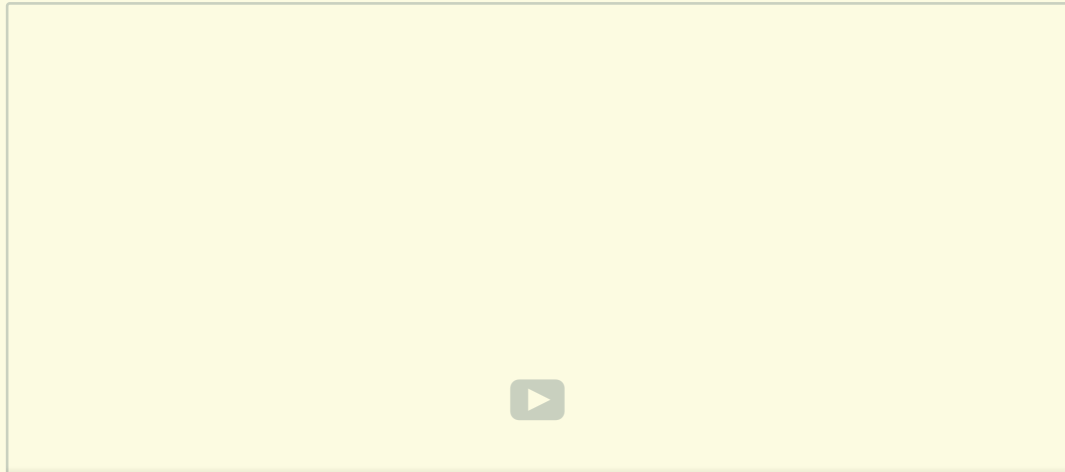
👍 1 💬 0 Reply Share ›



HenryW 🧑+ 🌟🌟🌟🌟🌟🌟

2 years ago

Two musical comments on this post:



see more

👍 0 💬 0 Reply Share ›



Linnaeus 🧑+ 🌟🌟🌟🌟🌟🌟

2 years ago

“It’s a child’s grave,” she told me. “Who would do that?”

A very, very shitty person.

👍 5 💬 0 Reply Share ›



colinday 🧑+ 🌟🌟🌟🌟🌟🌟

2 years ago

*The Female Union Band Society was a group of both free Black and Native women in the area. It was a sort of **fraternal** organization that provided what most of these existed for at the time—burial insurance.*

Shouldn't that be sororal?

👍 1 💬 0 Reply Share ›



Anna in PDX 🧑+ 🌟🌟🌟🌟🌟🌟

2 years ago

Gosh, I was really enjoying this post, until the end. What the fuck is wrong with white people?

👍 2 💬 0 Reply Share ›



This comment was deleted.



HenryW 🧑+ 🌟🌟🌟🌟🌟🌟 ➔ Guest

2 years ago

As Tacitus wrote:

Proprium humani ingenii est odisse quem laeseris.
It is human nature to hate the one whom you have hurt.

De Vita et Moribus Iulii Agricolae, 42
Life of Agricola, ch. 42

Life of Agricola, ch. 42

👍 2 🗨️ 0 Reply Share ›



Anna in PDX 🧑🏻 + 🇺🇸 🇺🇸 🇺🇸 🇺🇸 ➔ Guest

2 years ago

Yeah, I appreciated that book as well.

👍 1 🗨️ 0 Reply Share ›



caracal 🧑🏻 +

2 years ago

I live near the National Memorial Cemetery of the Pacific. I takes walks through it regularly. It's always a hive of activity between the constant maintenance, the regular burials, memorial services and tourists. It's an altogether majestic and serene place. As you might expect, it has some wonderful stories to tell. I recommend a visit to Sailor Jerry's grave. If you ever find yourself in Oahu, go visit, plan on spending 3-4 hours there.

👍 0 🗨️ 0 Reply Share ›



CDinCAfromPA 🧑🏻 + 🇺🇸 🇺🇸 🇺🇸 🇺🇸 +2

2 years ago

Thanks for this.

Posts like this are why I'll gladly accept Erik's reputed curmudgeonlyness.

👍 2 🗨️ 0 Reply Share ›



poloniousmonk 🧑🏻 + 🇺🇸 🇺🇸 🇺🇸

2 years ago

i'd like to point out that it's premature to assign a bigoted motive to the burn since we don't know the motivations of whomever leaves the toys. which, in the age of surveillance society, seems as suspect as pretending we can't figure out who Q is. maybe a white supremacist group of idiots [but i repeat myself] are attempting some sort of necromancy and vigilant Black defenders destroyed their sabbat?

👍 0 🗨️ 0 Reply Share ›



littlegreen 🇺🇸 🧑🏻 + 🇺🇸 🇺🇸 🇺🇸 +3

2 years ago

Good one, Erik. (Except now I'm crying in the middle of the day and I try to avoid that.)

👍 0 🗨️ 0 Reply Share ›



Percy Tierney 🧑🏻 + 🇺🇸

2 years ago

Retired cardiologist Kay Gilmour of Florida is keeping Erik's outstanding commentary an name.

"The more I got into it, the more interesting it became," she said. "The people in the cemetery are the history of our country. They are not just St. Nicholas but Florida and the United States," she said. "The lives of our Cemeterians reach out to tell their stories to all who will take the time to listen. They tell us how they lived and died to make our place in the world. They ask nothing more of us than our support in maintaining the dignity of their final resting place," she wrote in the book's introduction. "I started out to report on the lives of those persons actually buried in our neighborhood cemetery. However, my curiosity got the better of me and I began to research the ancestors of those folks."

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